

Chapter 84 - Ski Resort

February at Tamana was peak skiing season. Since the five had decided to head over early, they needed to return to their rooms to put on thick ski suits - the temperature outside was no joke.

When the five arrived at the ski resort bundled up tightly, it was still early, but there were already many tourists queuing at the entrance. Jiang Ming roughly estimated that if they queued normally, it would be at least half an hour before they could enter.

Fortunately, when Jiang Zhao had booked tickets, he'd gotten VIP passes, so they could go directly through the VIP entrance on the other side. Dana was even better off - she was an annual pass holder here, and even had her skiing equipment stored directly at the resort.

Inside the ski resort was a shop specializing in selling and renting equipment. After the five entered with their gear, Jiang Zhao walked over to Yan Lin's side.

"Miss Yan, do you want to change that board? We could pick something from this shop - the equipment quality here is excellent."

Hearing this, Dana also nodded beside them: "Yes, I picked my board from this shop. It's been with me for a long time - it's my baby." Speaking thus, she even patted the snowboard she was holding.

What Yan Lin was carrying was something she'd had the mall randomly deliver that day - completely black with the brand marked on the bottom. This brand of snowboard really wasn't very good, but Yan Lin had no desire to change it.

So she silently shook her head: "No need, this one is fine."

Seeing her refuse, the two didn't insist further.

70% of Tamana Mountain consisted of developed ski runs, divided into beginner, intermediate, and advanced slopes.

Among these three types, intermediate slopes made up the largest proportion, followed by beginner slopes, then advanced.

Of the group of five, Jiang Zhao and Jiang Ming were both quite good at recreational skiing. Jiang Zhao used a snowboard, Jiang Ming used skis¹, and both could handle advanced and intermediate slopes.

Meanwhile, Dana, who usually seemed too lazy to move, was actually a hidden expert who frequented terrain parks with various gradients, jumps, and obstacles - she was a seasoned skiing enthusiast.

Yan Lin and Feng Yue appeared to be the two least skilled skiers among the five.

So, to accommodate Feng Yue and Yan Lin, the other three all headed toward the intermediate slopes, which lived up to expectations by being packed with people.

Like Jiang Ming, Feng Yue used skis, and her intermediate slope skiing was just basic gliding - nothing like the fancy moves Jiang Zhao and Jiang Ming could pull off on intermediate slopes.

"You guys go to the advanced slopes. What's the point of wasting time here with me? I'm not a complete beginner who can't ski at all. I'd actually be more comfortable here." Feng Yue didn't want to spoil everyone's fun because of her, so she actively encouraged the group to switch slopes.

"We'll stay here with you. No need to switch slopes, and it's nice here too." Jiang Ming stubbornly refused to separate from Feng Yue.

Dana probably couldn't resist the temptation of higher-level slopes. After thinking for a moment: "Why don't you come to the advanced slopes with us? We can teach you there!"

Hearing this, Feng Yue was stunned for a few seconds, then quickly shook her head. She had never been on advanced slopes, and she hadn't even mastered intermediate slopes yet - she didn't dare go there.

"You guys go ahead. I'm not very good at skiing either, so I can stay here with Ah Yue." Yan Lin, who had been quietly standing aside, actively spoke up.

Jiang Zhao had been staying silent on the side, but Jiang Ming had the strongest reaction to these words among the group.

She was just about to open her mouth to protest when Jiang Zhao's thickly gloved hand covered her mouth, and she could only make "mmm mmm mmm" sounds.

Dana stood nearby, completely confused.

In the end, Jiang Zhao forcibly dragged Jiang Ming away, and seeing both of them leave, Dana followed. Finally, only Yan Lin and Feng Yue were left on the intermediate slope.

Yan Lin had expected Feng Yue to be angry about her staying on the intermediate slope with her, but Feng Yue showed no reaction at all. She just calmly put on her goggles and headed toward the cable car.

Knowing she was being ignored, Yan Lin could only silently carry her board and follow behind Feng Yue.

Meanwhile, Jiang Ming, who had been dragged away, finally broke free from Jiang Zhao's grip: "Jiang Zhao!"

Hearing Jiang Ming call his full name, Jiang Zhao knew she was truly angry and could only sigh helplessly.

Jiang Ming was fuming: "You just left those two who can barely ski there?!"

Jiang Zhao's expression was somewhat strange as he looked at Jiang Ming oddly: "Can barely ski? Who are you talking about?"

"Have you forgotten who taught Xiao Yue to ski when we first brought her skiing?" Jiang Zhao reached out to fix the hair he had accidentally messed up for her: "Yan Lin is probably the only one among us who could compete with Dana."

Jiang Zhao said this last sentence in Chinese, which Dana beside them couldn't understand.

Jiang Ming's expression changed, probably remembering some past events, though she still stubbornly worried about Feng Yue: "But we still can't just leave the two of them there! They... they have that kind of relationship..."

"Catherine, you should know that Xiao Yue personally agreed to let Yan Lin come along. Maybe they have something to work out between them. We shouldn't interfere."

Jiang Ming lowered her head and pouted, secretly glancing at Dana before saying in Chinese: "But I already called her here..."

Dana looked completely bewildered - what encrypted language were you speaking in Chinese?!

Jiang Zhao sighed and patted Jiang Ming's head: "Come on, let's enjoy the sport. We can't control Xiao Yue's affairs."

Jiang Ming dejectedly followed behind Jiang Zhao, and the three finally got on the cable car up the mountain.

Feng Yue and Yan Lin reached the top of the intermediate slope one after the other.

As the most extensive slope area, the intermediate slope naturally had the most visitors. Looking down from top to bottom, you could see many tourists in dark ski suits.

Feng Yue was probably infected by those tourists joyfully rushing downhill. Just as she was about to start skiing down, Yan Lin reached out and stopped her.

Feng Yue looked back in surprise and heard Yan Lin say: "Ah Yue, warm up first."

The intermediate slope was long, with more gradients and turns than beginner slopes, making injuries more likely. Yan Lin was right to have Feng Yue warm up first.

Feng Yue thought about it and took off her skis to do proper warm-up exercises in place.

Yan Lin silently accompanied her on the side. Although Feng Yue's attitude toward her wasn't particularly good, she still wanted to stay by her side.

The two stood aside quietly doing warm-up exercises. Once Feng Yue had loosened up her hands and feet, she finally looked directly at Yan Lin: "You don't have to stay here. You can go with them."

Probably no one understood better than Feng Yue how much Yan Lin loved skiing.

Yan Lin silently shook her head, then quietly settled beside her again.

Feng Yue observed her quietly for a while before turning to put on her skis and rushing down from the top of the intermediate slope.

The goggles blocked the wind and snow particles sweeping toward Feng Yue, her long hair draped over her shoulders was caught by the wind, and the rapidly passing scenery flashed by in her eyes.

The weightlessness from rushing down the slope made Feng Yue's heart clench tightly before being released again.

The excitement and exhilaration that extreme sports brought Feng Yue was completely different from ordinary exercise.

While skiing, Feng Yue felt like she was the freest person in this icy world.

Yan Lin followed behind Feng Yue on her snowboard at some distance. Even with the gap between them, Yan Lin could feel the other's joy and exhilaration at that moment.

Watching Feng Yue gradually become more skilled, Yan Lin suddenly remembered Feng Yue when she was first learning to ski.

Feng Yue's first contact with skiing had been under her guidance - she was the first person to teach Feng Yue to ski.

Back then, Feng Yue would look at her with admiring eyes after she demonstrated a skiing run.

Those dazzling, brilliant eyes still made her heart tremble when she remembered them.

But that Feng Yue was moving away from her.

Yan Lin's breath caught, and she accelerated to catch up, until she was more or less parallel with Feng Yue. Only then did the almost suffocating urgency in her heart ease somewhat.

She had caught up. She would catch up.

Yan Lin thought silently to herself.

The two reached the bottom almost simultaneously, and then Feng Yue immediately got back on the upward cable car, with Yan Lin following close behind.

After skiing like this three or four times, Feng Yue finally let out a satisfied breath. These runs had made her feel as light as if she'd shed a heavy burden.

So when Feng Yue went up to ski down again, she slowed her speed and paid more attention to the scenery along the way.

With Feng Yue's reduced speed and less concentrated attention, sudden sounds came from the slope behind her - a fear-filled scream and several hearty laughs.

These sudden sounds made Feng Yue's heart tighten. Her feet became unsteady, she stumbled, and her whole body fell sideways to the right.

Yan Lin was startled and quickly followed.

"Ah Yue! Are you okay?! Where did you fall? Are you hurt?" Yan Lin asked while removing the skis from Feng Yue's feet.

Feng Yue had just stumbled - the fall wasn't very painful. Since they couldn't stop too long in the middle of the slope, Feng Yue moved to the side with Yan Lin's help.

Once they'd moved aside, Feng Yue stood up and brushed the snow off herself: "I'm fine, just stumbled."

Yan Lin saw her moving normally and finally relaxed.

Then Yan Lin turned her attention to the culprits behind them who were screaming and shouting.

The one screaming was a girl, accompanied by a man holding up his phone to film. Listening to their conversation, they seemed to be a couple.

The girl was probably not used to intermediate slopes, so she cried out in fear, which startled Feng Yue and caused her to stumble inattentively.

Since Feng Yue wasn't knocked down by those two people, there was no reason to blame them. Feng Yue could only accept the bad luck.

Yan Lin helped Feng Yue put her skis back on, and the two slowly skied down.

Footnotes:

¹ Skis (双板): This refers to traditional two-ski setup, as opposed to snowboarding which uses a single board (单板).